the ruler of a kingdom that stretched from Kanyakumari to just short of Cochin.

Immediately after his victory Marthanda Varma made his way to Trivandrum, and there surrendered his new kingdom to Sri Padmanabhaswamy in the form of Lord Vishnu reclining on the serpent Ananatha, pledging that henceforth he and his descendants would rule Travancore as Padmanabha Dasa, or servants of the deity. However, it was made clear to him by the temple authorities that in their eyes he was by caste a Shudra and, as such, forbidden to enter the innermost precincts of his own temple.

But there was an important precedent in the form of the ancient rite of *Hiranyagarbha yagna* or 'golden womb sacrifice' by which a non-Kshatriya ruler might acquire legitimacy by undergoing a purification ritual. Originally that practice had involved sacrifice but over the years this had been replaced by *mahadanam*, or 'the making of great donations', by which the unqualified ruler could buy Kshatriya caste status by making large donations of gold. A century and a half earlier, another local ruler named Udayavarman had done just that when the Nambudiris at his court had refused to perform the rites. Udayavarman had responded by importing 237 Shivalli Brahmin families from Karnataka who were less particular than the Nambudiris. After receiving generous gifts of gold, they had subjected the raja to the required purification rituals by which he attained the status of Kshatriya.

It seems that the Nambudiris had learned their lesson, because when Marthanda Varma asked for promotion they obliged – but at a price. As well as being required to have a life-size golden cow built, 'under which he was forced to creep in order to be freed of his sins', the raja had also to ritually cleanse himself in a vast pot of gold (see illustration) which was then broken up for distribution to every Brahmin in his kingdom, the bulk of it going to the Nambudiris. A precedent had now been set whereby every new ruler of